Why do young Americans support redistribution?

Survey evidence on a widening U.S. age gap

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Structure

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2. Motivating Graphs
3. Summary of Finding
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    2. Univesal Zero Sum: DEI
    3. Zero-Sum (Growth of the Pie vs. Distribution of the Pie - Fairness)Reflection of Growin Inequality)
9. Comparison Existing Survey / Internationa Evidence
10. Understanding how this gap has evolved.

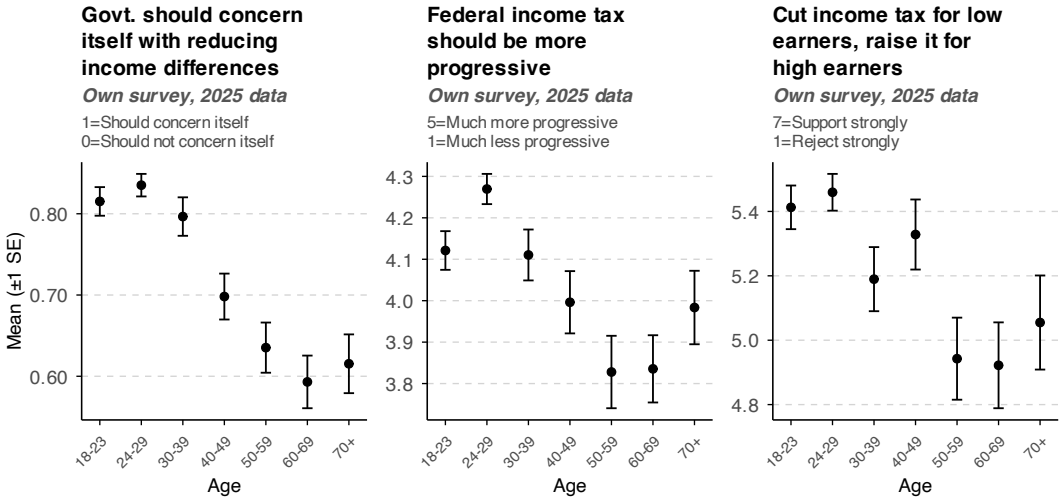
Why do young Americans have different preferences?

If the election were held today, how would you vote on Proposition 40, the one-time tax on billionaires?

POLITICO / Citrin Center (UC Berkeley) / TrueDot poll of California likely voters, fielded October 9–14, 2026

	Age			
	18–29	30–44	45–64	65+
Yes	64%	62%	44%	28%
No	18%	25%	49%	63%
Undecided	18%	12%	6%	10%
N (unweighted)	68	226	314	301

Current age gap on income redistribution



Age or cohort effects?

Two competing hypotheses:

- Lifecycle: currently low income + time discounting, present financial stress, long-term career/lifestyle risk, prospect of upward mobility.

  Largely *self-interest*-driven.
- Cohort divergence: experienced inequality, growth, mobility, housing prices, social safety net access, diversity, immigration. Shaped by political narratives and the supply of politicians/platforms.

  Largely *belief*-driven.

Summary of findings

1. It is not the economic position of the young: 26 measures of income, risk and prospects explain none of the gap.
2. It is what the young believe about the economy: zero-sum and deservingness beliefs account for much of the gap.
3. The age gap on redistribution grew from zero in the 1970s–80s to +0.5 SD today (half of the party gap, similar to the race gap, double the gender gap).
4. A similar age gap in beliefs has emerged.
   - Ongoing analysis: what drives these beliefs?

Our survey

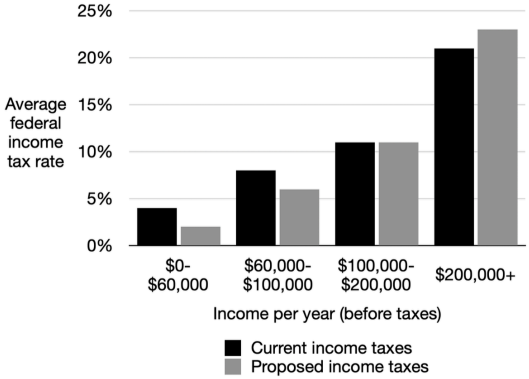
- Online survey of U.S. citizens, fielded on Prolific in spring 2025.
- $N = 2,415$, one half 18–30, one half > 30.
- 15 minutes on average, 92 questions.
- Covers current financial position, history, expectations, risks, beliefs about the economy, and values.
- Benchmarked against external surveys: Chinoy et al. (2026), GSS, ANES, and WVS/EVS.

Questions asked

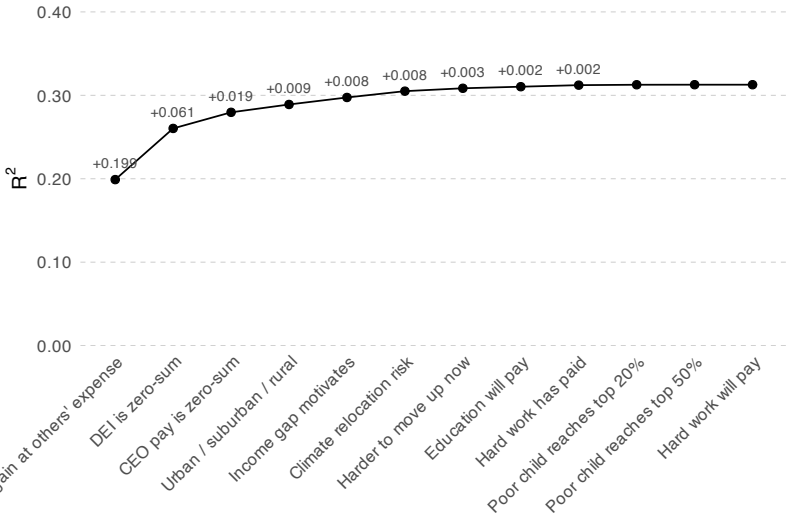
- Policy preferences: income redistribution (3), why preferences changed (2), alternative policies to support low-income (5).
- Economic position: current and expected income (12), future income needs (5), financial insecurity (4), AI/climate/housing/health risk (4), family/personal history (5), ambitions (5).
- Beliefs: incentive effects of taxation (2), zero-sum beliefs (4), mobility (4).
- Values: time discounting (7), generosity/universalism (2), materialism (2).

Core outcomes

1. Should the government concern itself with reducing income differences between rich and poor people?
2. Should the federal income tax be more progressive than it is now (redistributing more income from the rich to the poor)?
3. *Description of revenue-neutral tax.* Would you support or reject the proposed change?



Strongest correlates: add-one-in



Strongest corrlates: Shapley decomposition

Should the government concern itself with reducing income differences between rich and poor people?

Own survey, 2025

Question	% of R^2
People usually get rich at the expense of others rather than by creating value for others.	16.6%
DEI initiatives create opportunities for some at the expense of others.	13.9%
Large gains in CEO and executive salaries have been at the expense of the salaries of average workers.	12.1%
If taxes on high incomes are increased and taxes on low incomes are decreased, people will not work as hard.	9.1%
A large income gap is needed to motivate entrepreneurs to start businesses and innovate.	6.2%
— 83 questions with <5% omitted —	
Full model $R^2 = 0.37$, $N = 2{,}415$	

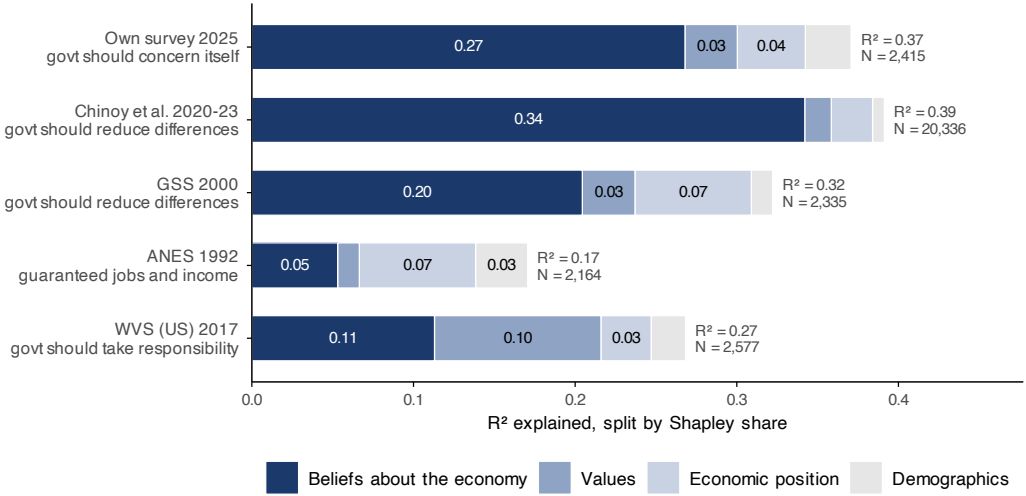
What accounts for the gap: Gelbach decomposition

Should the government concern itself with reducing income differences between rich and poor people?

Own survey, 2025

Question	Contribution	% of explained
People usually get rich at the expense of others rather than by creating value for others.	-0.037	43.7%
DEI initiatives create opportunities for some at the expense of others.	-0.019	22.3%
Rank of "opportunities for growth and advancement" among five things valued in a job.	-0.014	16.3%
What is the risk that you have to relocate due to climate events in the next 10 years?	-0.010	12.2%
— 65 questions with <10% omitted —		
Age gradient: bivariate -0.211, with all covariates -0.126		40.4%
N = 2,255		

Benchmarking: strongest correlates

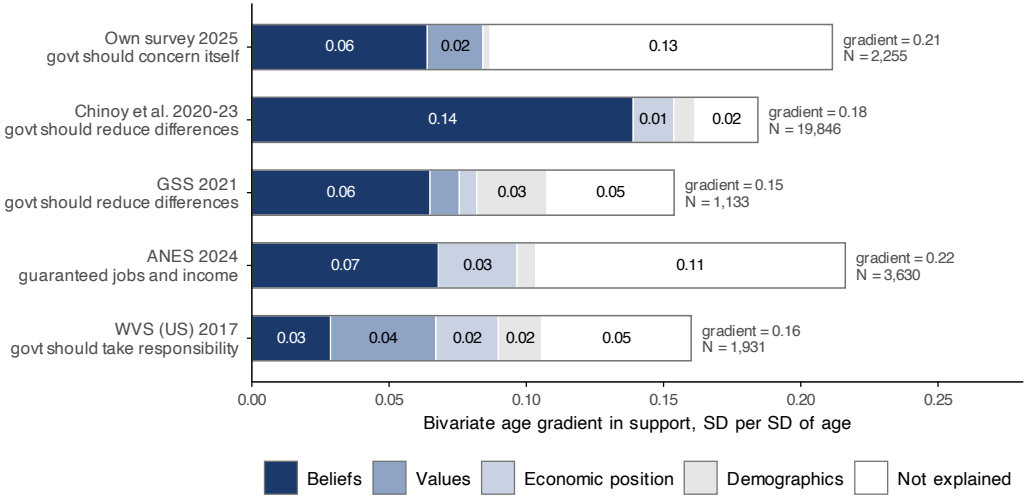


Strongest correlates in Chinoy et al. (2026)

Should the government reduce income differences between the rich and the poor?
Chinoy et al., 2020–23

Question	% of R^2
Generations of slavery and discrimination make it difficult for Black people to work their way out of the lower class.	16.5%
Do you believe racism in the U.S. is not a problem at all ... a very serious problem?	14.1%
If one income group becomes wealthier, it usually comes at the expense of other groups.	10.5%
How often do women experience discrimination or are made to feel inferior because of their gender?	9.6%
Success in life is pretty much determined by forces outside our control.	7.9%
If one ethnic group becomes richer, this generally comes at the expense of other groups.	7.5%
Incentivized guess: did the top 1%'s income gain come partly at the expense of the poorest 50%?	5.0%
How often can you trust the government to do what is right?	5.0%
— 30 questions with <5% omitted —	
Full model $R^2 = 0.39$, $N = 20{,}336$	

Benchmarking: what accounts for the age gap



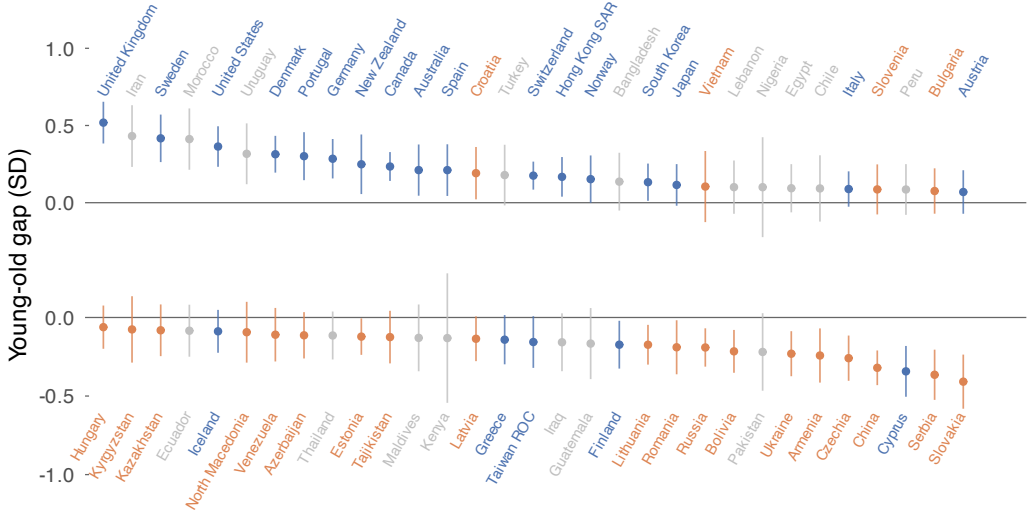
What accounts for the gap in Chinoy et al. (2026)

Should the government reduce income differences between the rich and the poor?

Chinoy et al., 2020–23

Question	Contribution	% of explained
If one income group becomes wealthier, it usually comes at the expense of other groups.	-0.032	19.9%
Do you believe racism in the U.S. is not a problem at all ... a very serious problem?	-0.027	17.0%
Success in life is pretty much determined by forces outside our control.	-0.025	15.7%
If one ethnic group becomes richer, this generally comes at the expense of other groups.	-0.020	12.3%
How often do women experience discrimination or are made to feel inferior because of their gender?	-0.019	11.7%
— 28 questions with <10% omitted —		
Age gradient: bivariate -0.184, with all covariates -0.023		87.6%
N = 19,846		

International age gradients in WVS/EVS 2017–2022



Discussion: is it zero-sum or deservingness?

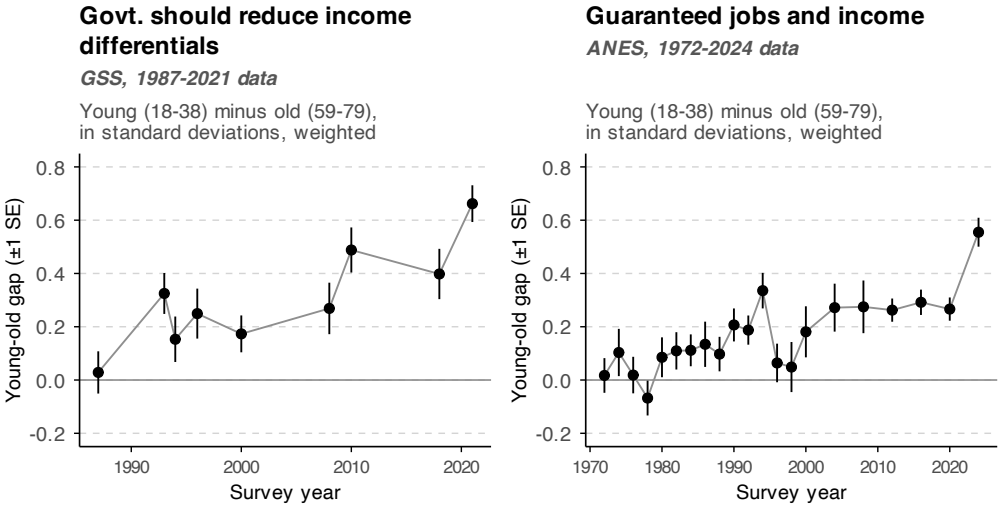
Related but distinct beliefs

- Positive-sum vs zero-sum: whether one's effort can grow the pie or one's gains are necessarily another's losses.
- Attribution/deservingness: whether one's gains were deserved or earned unfairly.

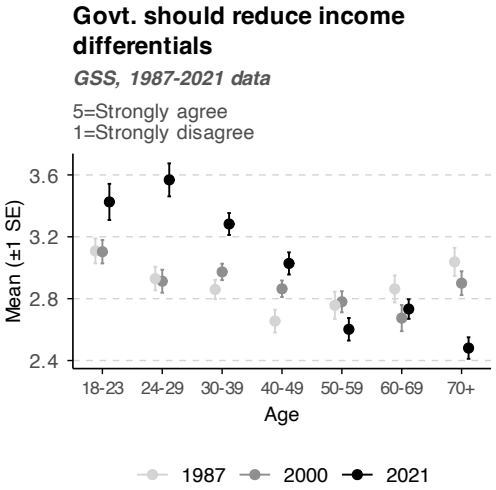
Observations

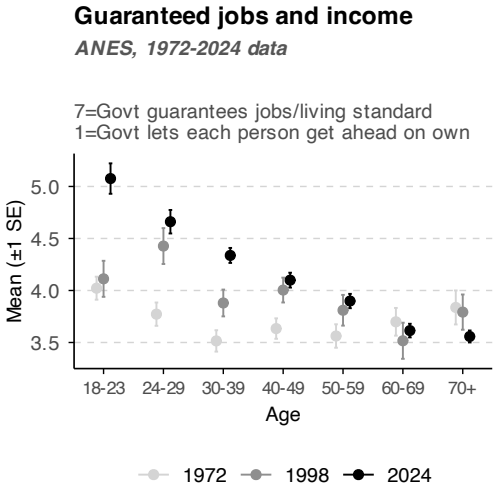
- Young people on average believe that CEOs are zero-sum but not DEI initiatives; zero-sum is not a universal belief.
- "Tax demotivates" and "gap motivates" address positive-sumness and predict preferences but have no age gap.

Young-old age gap increasing over time

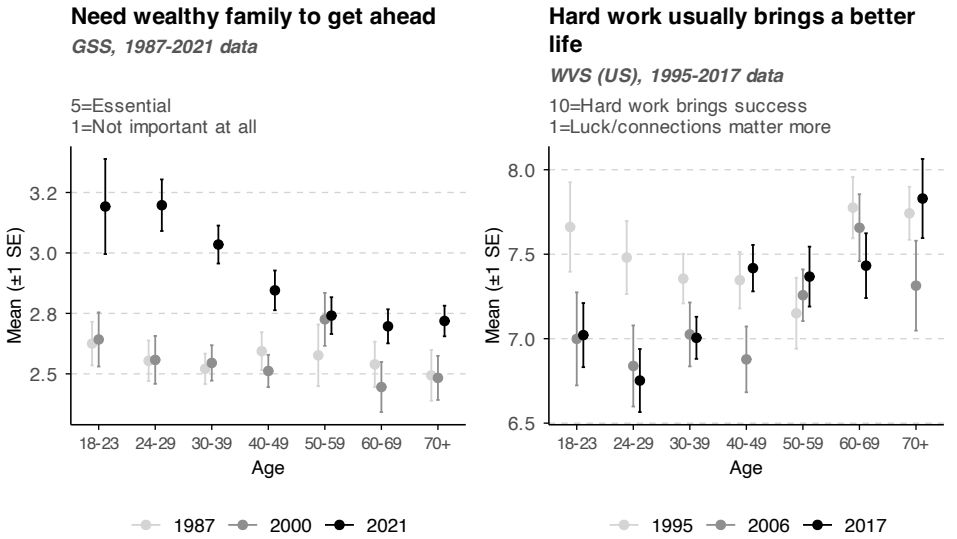


Cross-sectional age gradient steepening over time

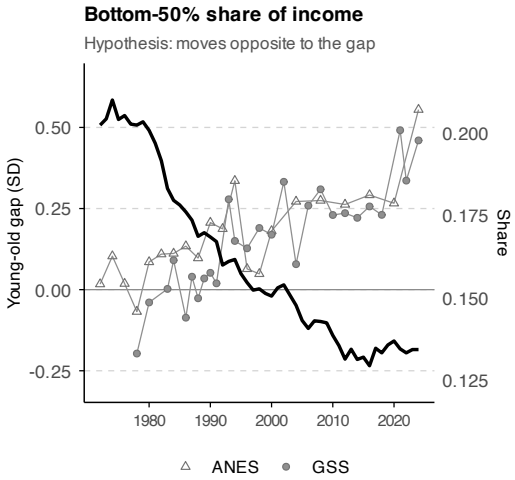


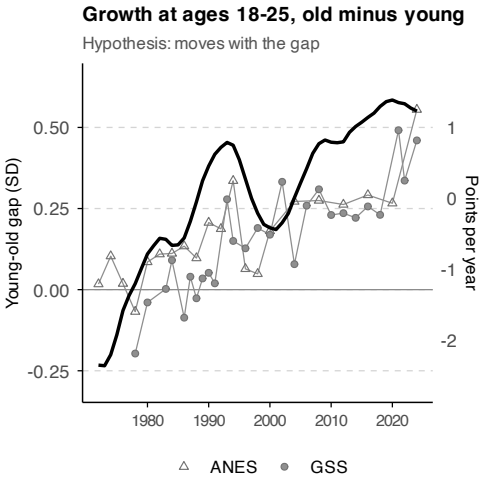


Steepening age gradient in deservingness beliefs



Investigating belief drivers





Preliminary findings

- Inequality, growth, and mobility alone do not explain any of the age gradient in cross-country analysis; the U.S. time series correlation is an outlier.
- Movement of older Americans' beliefs and non-formative-years placebo tests raise doubts about an imprinting story.
- Opposite age gradient on social security, emerging around 2020.
- U.S. has highest perceived age conflict among rich democracies. Recently, the young perceive more conflict than the old.
- No age gap among Black Americans, only White/Hispanic.
- 3/4 of age gap survives within-party; not just higher polarization.

Why is the US unique?

Possibilities:

- Old-age benefits and the political power of the old
- Two-party bundling of cultural and economic positions (majoritarian vs. proportional system)
- Political entrepreneurs (Sanders, Trump)

What explains sharp rise in gap post-2020?

- Prominent billionaires reshaping society (Musk, Bezos)
- Racial justice salience (BLM movement)
- Affordability crisis (inflation, housing) and youth unemployment
- Government debt worries (social security more salient)
- Elderly presidential candidates in 2020 and 2024

Future analysis

- Second survey wave
  - A more comprehensive questionnaire pairing existing questions with govt. trust, religiosity, and race-related beliefs.
  - In-depth measurement and differentiation of zero-sum and attribution beliefs.
  - An information provision or wording experiment generating exogenous belief variation.
- Geographic and micro variation
  - State and local-level age inequality measures: political representation (L2 voter files), policy tilt, real circumstances (housing, employment, etc.)
- Text analysis
  - Extracting zero-sum rich and zero-sum race narratives from Congressional speeches. Manifesto Project for cross-country.

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